CostOptima User Guide

CostOptima calculates PCM costs: you upload an input workbook, the system checks it against your company's master data and formulas, and you download a finished output workbook in the standard legacy layout. This guide covers how to sign in, how an admin sets the system up, and how to run and review calculations.

Getting started

Sign in

1. Open the CostOptima application; you'll see the sign-in page.
2. Enter your **Corporate Email** and **Password**. Use the eye icon to show or hide your password.
3. Click **Sign In**. If your company uses single sign-on, click **SSO Sign In** instead.

After signing in you land on the **Calculations** dashboard, or on the page you were trying to open.

What you can see and do

What appears in the menus and which buttons are active depends on your **role**. If a button is missing or greyed out, your role doesn't include that permission — ask your administrator.

If you want to…	You need permission for
Start or delete calculations	calculations
View past runs and logs	history
View or import master data	masters
Manage commodity data	commodity_config
Change workbook setup	workbook_config
Open settings pages	settings
Manage users	users
Manage roles and permissions	roles, permissions

Admin setup

Admins complete these steps once, in this order, before anyone can run a calculation. Each step depends on the one before it.

1. Create roles

1. Go to **Settings → Roles & Permissions**.
2. Click **Create Role**, enter a **Role Name** (must be unique) and an optional **Description**.
3. In the permission grid, tick the boxes for what this role may do. Roles are columns; permissions are rows grouped by module.
4. Use the search and filters to find permissions quickly, and **Export CSV** to download the full grid.

Typical roles are Admin, Analyst and Viewer. To add a new permission type, use **Manage Catalogue** and enter a Resource (e.g. calculations) and an Action (view, create, update or delete).

2. Add users

1. Go to **Settings → Users**.
2. Click **Invite User** and fill in **Name**, **Email**, **Temporary Password** and **Role**. Job Title and Department are optional.
3. Share the email and temporary password with the user so they can sign in.

To change a user's name, role, job title or department, click **Edit**; the email can't be changed. To remove access, click **Deactivate** — the account is disabled, not deleted, and **Reactivate** restores it.

3. Set up workbook structure

This tells CostOptima how to read your Excel files. Go to **Settings → Workbook Configuration** and define four levels:

Level	What it is	Key fields
Workbook Type	A kind of workbook, e.g. PCM master or input workbook	Code (can't change later), Name
Tab	A sheet in the workbook	Tab Name, Structure, Header Row
Section	A block of data within a sheet	Header Row, Data Start Row, Column Start/End, Header Type
Column	One Excel header mapped to a system field	Column Name, Header Name, Column Position, Data Type

The quickest way to set up a new format is **Configure From File**: upload a sample workbook, review the suggested sections and columns, then click **Apply All Sections** (or **Discard**). To add many columns to an existing tab, use **Bulk Add Columns**: pick the workbook, tab and section, upload a sample, click detect, review, and save.

4. Set master data rules

Go to **Settings → Master Configuration** and define, for each master table, which Excel tab feeds it, which fields are required, the unique keys that prevent duplicates, and the lookup keys calculations use to find records.

5. Import master data

1. Open **Masters** or **Commodity Types** from the menu and choose the data type.
2. Upload the Excel file.
3. Fix any errors the system reports (see Troubleshooting) and upload again.
4. When the import succeeds, the data is saved and used by every future calculation.

6. Configure formulas

Go to **Settings → Formula Repository**. Each formula has a code, an optional commodity scope, the expression, its input fields, an Active flag and a version/effective date. Only active formulas are used.

7. Configure output templates

Go to **Settings → Output Templates** to view and update the templates that shape the output workbook. If the PCM Sheet Metal output looks wrong, use **Reset** to restore the standard template.

8. Check app settings

Settings → App Configuration holds system-wide values such as the PCM engine definition, output paths, email and SSO settings. Change these only with your technical team.

Running a calculation

A calculation takes one PCM input workbook (.xlsx) and produces one output workbook. Go to **Calculations** and click **New Calculation** to open the five-step wizard.

Step 1 — Enter calculation details

Fill in **Project Name** and **Description** (both required). **Notify Email** is optional, but email notifications may not be switched on yet. Save this step to unlock the upload.

Step 2 — Upload the input workbook

Upload your PCM input file as a single .xlsx workbook. It normally contains the BOM, Hard, SBC and PF sheets, with Paint optional. CostOptima then shows:

- a preview of the first rows and columns, so you can confirm it's the right file;
- the sheet names it found in the workbook;
- an automatic check of the data, which starts right away.

Step 3 — Review the validation checklist

Each check shows one of three results:

Result	Meaning	What to do
Success	Check passed	Nothing
Warning	Calculation can run, but something needs attention	Review; fix if it affects the result
Error	Calculation is blocked	Fix the file or setup, then upload again

The checks confirm that required sheets, columns and values are present, master data exists, formula inputs can be found, the commodity can be processed, and an output template exists.

Step 4 — Calculate

When there are no errors, click **Generate Output Workbook**. The system combines your uploaded data with the master data, formulas and settings in the database, and shows progress messages as it runs.

Step 5 — Download the result

When the status shows **Completed**, download the output workbook. You'll also see whether an email notification was sent and the full log of the run.

Reviewing results

Calculations dashboard

The **Calculations** page lists every run with its Calc ID, input file (BOM), Status, start and completion times, and the commodities processed.

- **New Calculation** starts a new run.
- **Download All** downloads the outputs of all runs.
- **Delete All** removes every calculation record. This can't be undone, so use it with care.

History and logs

The **History** page lists past runs. Select a run and click **View Logs** to see its step-by-step log: each line has a timestamp, level, process and message. Logs are the first place to look when a run fails or a number looks wrong.

Audit Logs (admins)

Settings → Audit Logs records who changed what and when. Search by text, filter by entity and by action (created, updated, deleted), then click **Search**; **Reset** clears the filters. Each entry shows the entity, action, details, status, the user who made the change and the timestamp.

Updating data and re-running

When rates, master data, formulas or templates change, an admin updates them in Settings or re-imports the data. Then start a **New Calculation** with the same input file; the new run uses the latest values.

Your profile

The **Profile** page shows your name, email, department, job title, your role, and the permission groups you have. To change any of these, ask an administrator.

PDF Converter

Use the **PDF Converter** when your source data arrives as a PDF.

1. Upload the PDF.
2. Wait while the system extracts the data.
3. Review the extracted preview.
4. Confirm it, or correct any mistakes.
5. Save or download the converted data.

Troubleshooting

Import errors

Message or problem	What it means	How to fix it
Missing required column	A column the setup expects isn't in the file	Add the column, or check the header spelling
Missing required value	A required cell is blank	Fill in the row and column shown

Message or problem	What it means	How to fix it
Invalid data type	A cell has the wrong kind of value, e.g. text in a number column	Correct the cell shown
Duplicate unique key	Two rows share a value that must be unique	Remove or merge the duplicate rows
Unknown tab	The file has a sheet the setup doesn't recognize	Check the sheet name, or ask an admin to add it
Empty file	The file has no data	Upload the correct file
Unsupported file type	The file isn't an accepted format	Save it as .xlsx and upload again

Calculation won't run

- **Generate Output Workbook is locked**: at least one check in the validation checklist is an Error. Fix it and upload again.
- **Master data missing or ambiguous**: the lookup found no record, or more than one. Ask an admin to import or correct the master data.
- **Formula input can't be found**: the file or database lacks a field a formula needs. Check the file's columns, or ask an admin.
- **Output template missing**: ask an admin to add or reset the template in Output Templates.

Access and sign-in

- **A menu or button is missing**: your role doesn't include that permission. Ask an admin.
- **Forgot your password**: the Forgot Password link may not work yet. Ask an admin to help you regain access.
- **Keep me signed in**: this option may not keep you signed in longer yet.

No email received

Email notifications and invitation emails may not be set up yet. Check the result page or the History page for your run's status, and share login details with new users directly.